maturity, and mutual respect, to make things work. I had just exceeded 11,000 runs in Test cricket and felt confident of adding more. It meant a lot when Andrew Strauss, my old opening partner, spoke about my determination, conviction and pride.

Joe had had his moments. I don't know what went on in that Walkabout bar in Birmingham back in 2013, when he was supposedly punched by David Warner. I'd left by then and, frankly, didn't bother to find out because I couldn't have cared less. It was blown out of proportion and as relatively sensible adults they made up.

He retained the cheekiness that made him claim that catch against me on his debut. He could still be mischievous, and push people to the limits by teasing them unmercifully, but as soon as he took the captaincy, he understood the responsibilities of the role. All of us learn on the job, to a greater or lesser degree.

He came to me for a chat before his first series, against South Africa. It might seem the most natural thing in the world to do, but it was also one of the most difficult, because of what others might read into it. I lived up to my immediate promise, that I would be there as a sounding board, if required, and I would do nothing to tread on his toes. It had to be his team, in his image. He said certain things in certain team meetings, particularly about our batting, that I would not have said. It's not wrong that we should hold diametrically opposed views on something we knew so well; there are two sides to every argument. I didn't air my side because I didn't want him to feel I was putting him under any pressure.

We spoke about general principles, but he had to find his own way. It took between two and three years for me to feel truly comfortable in the job, which is roughly where he is now. That initial spell takes a lot out of you, particularly mentally. You almost wish you could programme the lessons, reset and go again.

We live and learn. We stumble, fall and rise again. We separate the myths and cherish the realities. We discover what is important, and what is an indulgence. I have never forgotten Andy Flower's observation when he told me I was the new England captain in that meeting room in Southampton: 'Just because you've got the armband, it doesn't mean you know everything.'

You know what? He was right.